



Review

Introduction to radiomics for a clinical audience



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ARTICLE INFORMATION

Article history:

Received 2 August 2022

Accepted 31 August 2022

Radiomics is a rapidly developing field of research focused on the extraction of quantitative features from medical images, thus converting these digital images into minable, high-dimensional data, which offer unique biological information that can enhance our understanding of disease processes and provide clinical decision support. To date, most radiomics research has been focused on oncological applications; however, it is increasingly being used in a raft of other diseases. This review gives an overview of radiomics for a clinical audience, including the radiomics pipeline and the common pitfalls associated with each stage. Key studies in oncology are presented with a focus on both those that use radiomics analysis alone and those that integrate its use with other multimodal data streams. Importantly, clinical applications outside oncology are also presented. Finally, we conclude by offering a vision for radiomics research in the future, including how it might impact our practice as radiologists.

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Introduction

Radiological imaging is a key component in the delivery of safe and efficient healthcare across the world. It is unique in offering spatially resolved, three-dimensional information about disease, which is acquired non-invasively and, upon serial imaging, allows for temporal comparison. Generally, radiological image interpretation is characterised by qualitative evaluation, which is often based on experience and prone to subjectivity,¹ or simple

summary metrics such as lesion diameter or metabolic activity. Consequently, only a fraction of the wealth of quantitative information is extracted from medical images in clinical workflows.² The field of radiomics focuses on the extraction of quantitative features from digital images, which converts them into mineable high-dimensional data.² The driving hypothesis is that these features reflect the underlying biology but are imperceptible through the traditional visual inspection of current radiological practice.^{3,4}

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The theory underpinning radiomics was first developed for the assessment of aerial photography⁵ before its general application for a wide variety of image classification tasks.⁶ Although early uses included exploring its potential in aiding the diagnosis of rheumatic heart disease⁷ and classification of pulmonary disease on chest radiographs,⁸ much of its more recent development has been focused in oncology² (see Figs 1 and 2).

Radiomics has developed as an offshoot of the wider “omics” fields in molecular biology. There, the advent of cost-efficient high-throughput techniques, advances in the fields of machine learning (ML) and artificial intelligence (AI), and computational power sufficient to process the downstream information has allowed extraction of huge

volumes of highly complex data from multiple dimensions of disease molecular biology, including its DNA (“genomics”), RNA (“transcriptomics”), and associated proteins (“proteomics”), all of which can be extracted from a single biopsy.^{2,9} Integrating these approaches allows a more holistic understanding of disease and helps to bridge the gap between genotype and phenotype.^{9–11}

Radiomics, unlike the other “omics”, is based on radiological imaging rather than invasive biopsy or molecular assays. The latter two may only capture disease at a specific anatomical site, or within a small portion of a tumour, are expensive to acquire, onerous for patients, and often impractical to take from more than one disease site or at serial time-points.¹² Radiomics analysis is performed on

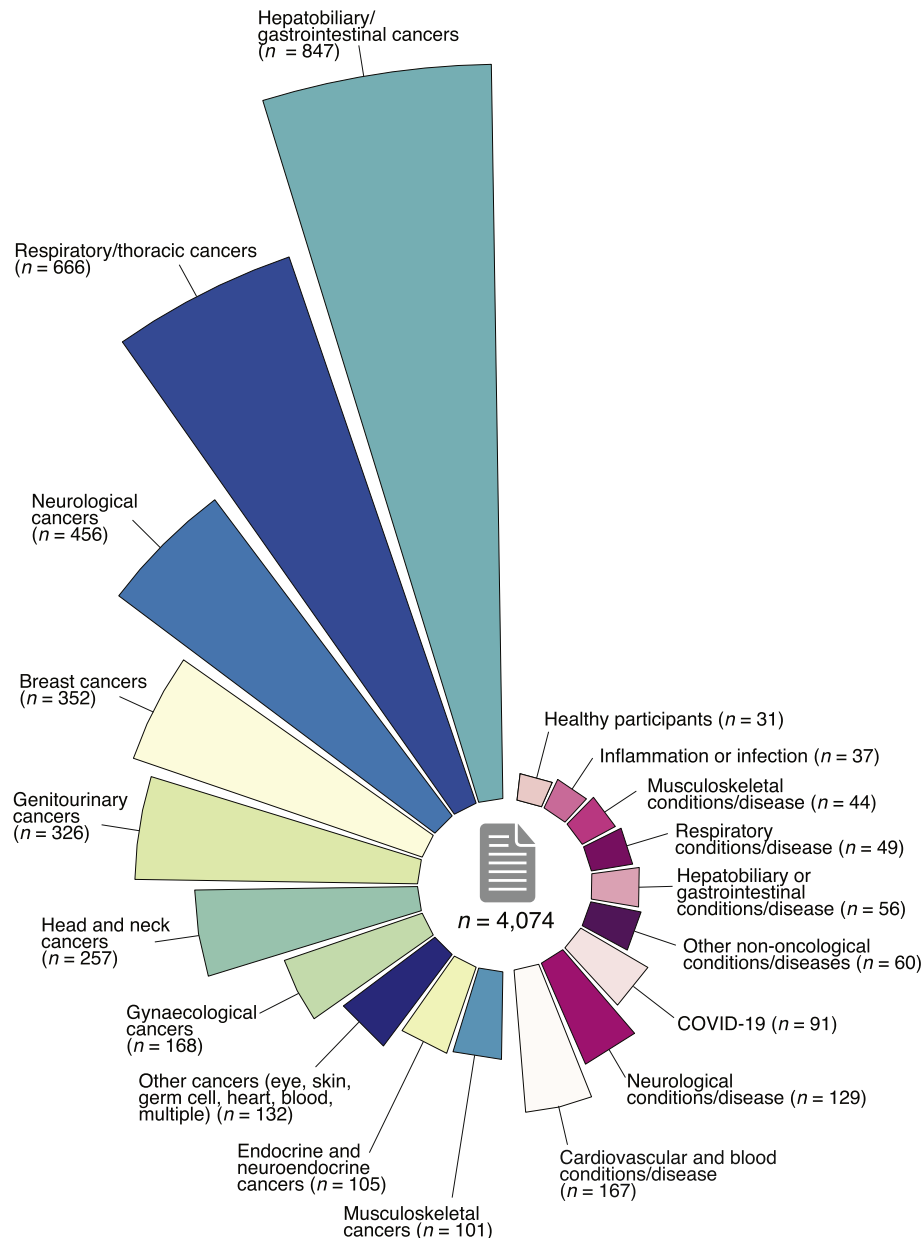


Figure 1 Circular bar chart showing the number of oncological and non-oncological radiomics studies published in PubMed. These exclude non-primary sources (reviews, proceedings, and errata), investigations on non-human models, and technical articles that do not interrogate a specific cancer site or condition/disease. At least 4,074 articles have been published as of 12 May 2022.

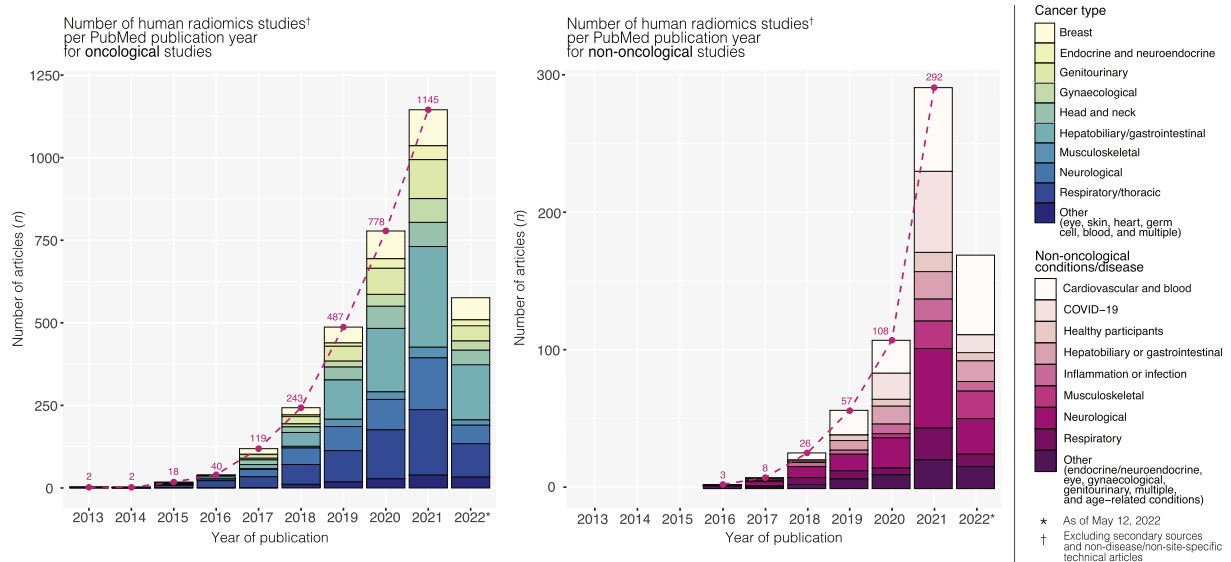


Figure 2 Bar charts showing the number of oncological- and non-oncological radiomics studies according to year of publication. After the word “radiomics” was coined in 2012 by Lambin *et al.*,²⁶⁰ primary research articles investigating radiomics have materialised in the oncology space by 2013 and in other diseases by 2016—the number of articles for both areas have grown exponentially since then.

images acquired from standard imaging equipment at single or multiple time points during the course of a patient's routine clinical care, thus requiring no additional imaging to be performed and ideally covers the whole extent of a disease taking into account inter-lesional differences or heterogeneity.¹ The maximal utility of radiomics will likely be in its integration into other multimodal data. Models integrating radiomics signatures with genomic and clinico-pathological information have shown improved prediction of disease outcome.^{13–16}

This article aims to give an introduction to radiomics for a clinical audience, while highlighting recent developments in the field, and presenting a vision for future clinical applications of the technology, and how they will impact our practice as radiologists.

The process of radiomics extraction: more than meets the eye

This overview of the extraction process is focused on “traditional” radiomics analyses based on pre-set feature definitions (also called handcrafted features), as opposed to those based on deep learning (DL; see Fig 3 for overview of the radiomics pipeline). The process of radiomics analysis begins with the definition of the study aims and clinical question, as this will inform the optimal modality and protocol of medical imaging to be assessed, the regions of interest within the images, and ultimately the statistical analysis that will be performed.

Image acquisition

Radiomics analysis may be performed on images from multiple different techniques; however, work focusing on the use of computed tomography (CT) or magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) predominates within the published

literature. Multiple intrinsic factors relating to image acquisition have potential to influence the radiomics signatures that are obtained, including hardware (scanner make and model), acquisition parameters (tube voltage and tube current for CT, field strength and pulse sequence for MRI, contrast medium administration for any technique) and reconstruction parameters (filters, voxel size), although the precise impact of such factors is the subject of ongoing debate and investigation.¹⁷

Segmentation

Before analysis can be performed, the images must undergo segmentation, which is the process of delineating the regions from which the features will be calculated. What constitutes the region of interest will depend on the aims of the study and could, for example, be a tumour on CT or MRI, or an area of opacity on radiographs.¹⁸

One of the key limitations of radiomics has been the time-consuming nature of manual image segmentation, performed slice-by-slice by an expert radiologist. Although this remains common, there is an increasing trend towards AI-based automated segmentation approaches, including fully or semi-automated segmentation (the latter with manual correction) using ML or neural network-based DL, although generalisability of such algorithms remains a limiting factor.¹⁹

Semi-automated segmentation has been shown to improve the repeatability and robustness of some radiomics features²⁰; however, both manual^{4,12} and semi-automated⁴ segmentations carry the risk of considerable inter-reader variability, for instance due to the subjective assessment of lesions with ill-defined borders, which results in unstable radiomics features.¹⁷ Therefore, ideally, multiple readers should segment at least a subset of the scans used for a radiomics study and some readers should also repeat their

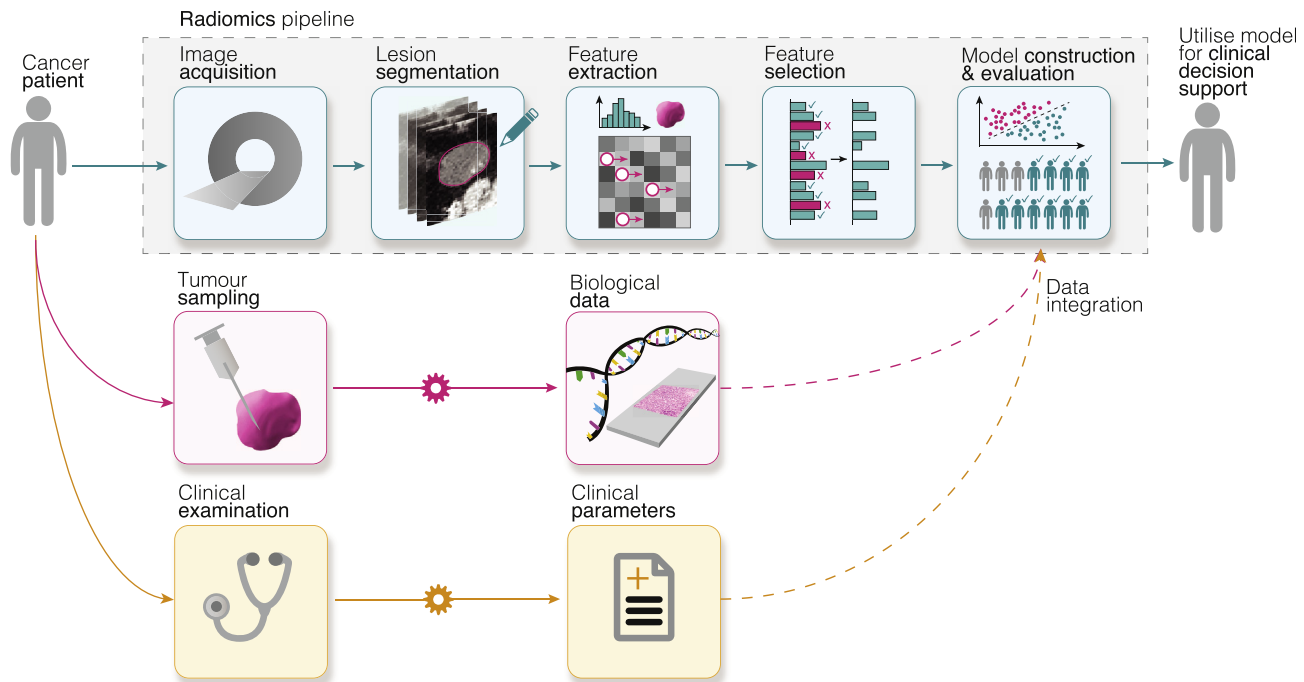


Figure 3 Schematic illustration of a typical radiomics pipeline. Radiological images acquired from medical scanners are first segmented to constrain radiomics analyses to the volume of interest (VOI), e.g., the tumour lesion. Radiomic features describing morphologic and textural characteristics are then extracted from VOIs. Because a large number of features tend to be computed, feature selection aims to identify which of these features are stable, non-redundant, and/or robust to any intrinsic dependencies (e.g., tumour volume). The result is a reduced set of only reliable radiomics features (“radiomics signature”), which are then used to construct, train, and evaluate mathematical models to predict outcomes (e.g., disease classification, treatment response, and survival). At this stage, non-imaging datasets, such as biological and clinical data, may also be integrated to develop holistic radiomics models that can be used as supporting tools for clinical decision-making.

segmentations after a period of time to assess the inter-reader variability and repeatability of radiomics. Focusing on radiomics features that show high repeatability and low inter-reader variability can be a very important step in the process of feature selection. AI-based automated segmentation is expected to partly alleviate the problem of inter-reader variability,^{2,4,12} but compared to human readers they may be more sensitive to noise and artefacts²¹; however, it is still recommended that AI-based automated segmentations are reviewed and modified by a specialty reader if necessary.^{2,12} Compared to human readers, AI-based segmenting tools can be less accurate due to high heterogeneity of the appearance of tumours, image noise, and artefacts.²¹

Multiple software packages are available for image segmentation and the extraction of radiomics features, including open-source and proprietary versions. Examples include 3D Slicer (3D Slicer community, <https://www.slicer.org/>), Microsoft advanced image labeller (project InnerEye, Microsoft, Redmond, WA, USA), and MIM software (MIM Software, Cleveland, OH, USA).

Image processing

Radiomics features extracted from a scan are sensitive to small changes in voxel intensity value and region of interest (ROI) size, which are dependent on the local imaging protocol, scanner make and model, and segmentation, which can affect the performance of a radiomics-based prediction

model in different imaging conditions.^{2,12,17,21,22} Therefore, following segmentation, a number of steps may be taken to harmonise the images from which features will be extracted. Harmonisation is a group of approaches that aim to produce consistent radiomics features from images acquired with different protocols.^{3,17,23–25}

Many texture feature sets require isotropic voxel spacing to allow comparison between data from different cohorts. Range re-segmentation or intensity outlier filtering is performed to remove outlier voxels from the segmented region that fall outside of a specified range of grey levels.¹⁸ Prior to feature calculation, the imaging data undergoes discretisation, a process by which individual voxel values are grouped into contiguous intervals (or “bins”).^{18,26}

Factors influencing the image produced, including imaging method, protocol, and relevant clinical conditions such as blood glucose in 2-[¹⁸F]-fluoro-2-deoxy-D-glucose (¹⁸F-FDG) positron-emission tomography (PET)¹⁷ should be reported along with any harmonisation methods used, so that they can be considered when assessing and comparing studies.

Radiomics feature extraction

Medical image analysis has traditionally focused on qualitative assessment of visually appreciable “semantic” features, such as the size, shape, and contrast-enhancement of a lesion. Radiomics allows for a quantitative assessment of such features, and for the mathematical extraction of

“agnostic” features that are not easily perceptible to the human eye, such as histogram features and texture analysis.² Shape analysis can include simple descriptions of size, such as dimensions; however, more complex topological characterisations may be extracted, such as roundness, compactness, spiculation, or convexity.¹⁷ Texture features are the statistical interrelationships of the voxel intensities within the ROI.²⁷ First-order statistics (simple histogram features) relate to the properties of individual voxels without reference to their spatial distribution, such as mean, maximum, and standard deviation and also histogram skewness and kurtosis. Higher-order statistics, such as a grey-level co-occurrence matrix (GLCM) features (also known as Haralick features), grey-level run length matrix (GLRLM) features, and grey-level size zone matrix (GLSZM) features are also employed to assess the spatial relationship between voxels with certain intensity values systematically. Using predefined formulas, features describing these different matrices can then be calculated using standalone software or packages for integration into coding environments, such as Python or MATLAB (e.g., PyRadiomics, TextRAD, MaZda, IBEX, CERR).²⁸ Full lists of these so called “handcrafted” features including the standardised formulas to be used for their computation can be found on the International Biomarker Standardisation Initiative’s (IBSI’s) website.²⁹ Different filters may be applied to the original image to focus on a different frequency domain within the image, examples include wavelet and Gaussian filters.³⁰

It has previously been reported that different software platforms could yield non-identical radiomics features calculations, calling into doubt the cross-platform reproducibility of the derived radiomics signatures.^{23,31} Investigators are advised to conform to abovementioned guidelines published by the IBSI, and prospective investigators are encouraged to use IBSI-compliant software.¹⁸

Dimensionality reduction

Numerous features may be extracted, with provision for >100 features in many commonly used software packages increasing to >1,000 with the application of filters; however, only a relatively small proportion are likely to contribute significantly to a radiomics signature developed for the prediction of a clinically meaningful variable. Dimensionality reduction is a process by which the features are identified are least redundant, and this process contributes the most value to a generalisable radiomics model. This step is essential to avoid the issue of overfitting, which occurs when a model corresponds too closely to the training data and learns the noise within it rather than the underlying features relevant for robust predictions. Radiomics data sets are often relatively small with the number of extracted features exceeding the number of samples available for analysis, resulting in high dimensionality datasets particularly prone to overfitting.³² Multiple strategies may be employed to reduce feature sets.^{4,33,34} Approaches commonly include feature selection mechanisms such as ranking by mathematic criteria (intra-class correlation coefficients) or ranking features by importance metrics, and feature extraction methods

in which the feature space is transformed to yield a new, smaller set of relevant features (e.g., linear discriminant analysis and principal component analysis [PCA]).

Model construction and evaluation

Both supervised and unsupervised learning can be applied in radiomics research. Unsupervised approaches do not necessarily require labelled training data and aim to uncover hidden structures, patterns, or sub-concepts in the data. Examples include clustering techniques and PCA.³⁵ It can then be determined whether these patterns have an association with the desired outcome.³⁶

In a supervised approach, the radiomics model is fitted to the target variable or study endpoint, for example, tumour histology or disease progression, and will typically incorporate the most strongly predictive radiomics features.³⁶ Least absolute shrinkage and selection operator (LASSO) is a very popular supervised ML method in which the process of feature selection happens in tandem with the model construction (a regression analysis is applied on the training data and features with a coefficient of zero are removed).³⁵ In contrast, feature selection and model construction happen separately in recursive feature elimination support vector machines (SVM-RFE), where the model needs to be rebuilt again after the selection of the features.³⁷

Supervised ML models are trained on a subset of the available images called the “training” data. Then, the performance and generalisability of the model is evaluated by validation testing. Two types of validation approach exist. The first approach, internal validation, makes use of similar data from which the model was derived. Popular examples of this approach are the holdout, and cross-validation methods. In the hold-out method the original dataset is split in two, with the model developed on the training subset, and then tested on the remainder of the data. For smaller sample sizes, cross validation is typically performed, where the data are split into several “folds” and then used sequentially to train and to validate the model.³⁸ The second approach is called external validation, where the data used to test model performance are structurally different to the data used to train the model and have usually been acquired from a separate institution in a different region.³⁹

The risk of bias in the model can be reduced by using large enough data sets obtained across multiple centres and populations; however, a perennial issue within the field of radiomics is that of small sample sizes, often comprising only a few hundred cases.² There are several possible reasons for this, including the labour-intensive nature of manual segmentation, and restricted access to external data.³⁸

Guidelines for model development

Feature extraction and selection

Different software and calculation methods are used to extract radiomics features from a scan. The IBSI is designed to standardise calculation methods,¹⁸ but there is still variation in the quantitative output based on platform and

software version, which may impact predictive power.²³ IBSI compliance, feature extraction, software type and version are therefore important to report.²³

With a higher number of features, there is an increasing chance that some irrelevant features happen to correlate with the outcome in the sample population, creating a danger of over-fitting the radiomics model to the sample, instead of to the population as a whole.^{2,3,12,24,40} Validation helps identify overfitting,³ as an over-fitted model would perform well on the test dataset but poorly on new data.^{3,24} Validation should ideally be performed on an external dataset to provide a more realistic estimate of the model's performance^{12,17}; however, external validation is as rare as 6% in published literature.⁴¹ Options to limit over-fitting include using fewer radiomics features, such as in hand-crafted radiomics,⁴⁰ using a larger sample size,¹² or reducing the number of radiomics features assessed by the model using unsupervised feature selection.^{3,12}

Evaluating the quality of radiomics publications

Performance metrics should include sensitivity and specificity in addition to summary metrics such as accuracy, to ensure that possible training biases are adequately captured. The importance of including such detail is highlighted in cases of class imbalance, a situation where most of the data present belongs to only one class label, such as disease presence for example. A model trained to predict a disease that affects 1 in 100 people might achieve 99% accuracy by labelling all possible patients as disease free, but yields 0% sensitivity, and thus have no practical clinical utility.³

Published radiomics research is of variable quality regarding methodology, validation, and reporting of results.⁴ There are tools available to assess the quality of a publication, such as the Radiomics Quality Score (RQS). Scored out of 36, it includes points for study design, statistical analysis, reporting of results, and open access to the tools and data used.⁴² Previous studies suggest that the current standard of published literature is insufficient based on RQS.⁴ The RQS itself, however, is not a comprehensive assessment of quality, as, for example, it does not include points for harmonisation techniques.^{3,43}

DL methods can bypass the need for segmentation and feature extraction, and instead assess the prognostic value of each voxel or area in a scan²¹ but are not the focus of this review. They come with their own inherent pitfalls, where the AI tool may draw spurious associations to the prognosis that are difficult to check as the results of DL tools can be difficult to understand or interpret biologically.²⁴ Some pitfalls of DL methods not captured by the RQS are included in the Checklist for AI in Medical Imaging (CLAIM), for example, points for explainability or interpretability using saliency maps⁴⁴ (see Fig 4 for further information on DL-based approaches, and saliency maps). Other tools also exist to both help design and evaluate research, such as transparent reporting of a multivariable prediction model for individual prognosis or diagnosis (TRIPOD), prediction model risk of bias assessment tool (PROBAST), their

extensions for AI and ML tools TRIPOD-AI and PROBAST-AI (both currently in development), and Quality Assessment of Diagnostic Accuracy Studies (QUADAS).^{45,46}

Clinical applications of radiomics

Oncological applications of radiomics

As illustrated in Figs 1 and 2, the field of radiomics research has, to date, been dominated by studies in oncology. Radiomics tools have been used in studies related to screening, disease detection, diagnosis, staging and prognosis, finding and predicting biological correlates, prediction of treatment response, and those that further our understanding of key oncogenic processes.⁴⁷ This section will highlight studies related to the prediction of biological correlates, stage and treatment response, in addition to studies that integrate radiomics and other multi-modal data streams.

Predicting histological or molecular features of tumours, and their stage

Accurate biological subtyping is paramount to the selection of oncological treatment, but can be limited by access of sufficient diagnostic tissue and tumour heterogeneity. The use of radiomics in predicting key histotypes has been researched extensively to address this challenge in a variety of tumour types: these have included oestrogen receptor (ER)/progesterone receptor (PR)/human epidermal growth factor receptor 2 (HER2) status prediction from MRI, PET/CT, mammography and low-dose CT in breast cancer,^{48,49} and the prediction of small-cell or non-small-cell adenocarcinoma/squamous and large-cell pathologies from CT or PET/CT at lung cancer diagnosis.^{50–52} Radiomics predictors of microvascular invasion, a histopathological predictor of poor recurrence-free and overall survival in surgically treated hepatocellular carcinoma (HCC), have also been reported.^{53–55}

With regard to studies aiming to predict the mutational status of specific genes, published work to date has focused predominantly on established biomarkers currently applied in cancer therapy. These include abnormalities affecting EGFR/ALK, BRCA, KRAS/BRAF/NRAS, IDH/1p19q (co-deletion), and VHL/BAP1/PBRM1 in lung, breast, colorectal, central nervous system (CNS), and renal cancers, respectively (as reviewed in⁵⁶). Gene expression-based biomarkers predicted by radiomics have included OncotypeDX in breast cancer,^{57,58} as well as key prognostic transcriptomic subtypes including in CNS,^{59–61} hepatobiliary,⁶² lung⁶³ and gynaecological⁶⁴ tumours. Radiomics-based DNA or RNA methylation status prediction has also been reported, such as for MGMT promoter methylation in glioblastoma,^{65–67} m6A RNA methylation in urothelial tumours,⁶⁸ and methylation-based subgrouping in renal cell carcinoma⁶⁹ and squamous cell carcinomas of the oral cavity, larynx, or pharynx.⁷⁰

With the rising prominence of immune checkpoint inhibitors (ICIs) in oncology, radiomics research to predict molecular biomarkers of ICI response has expanded in

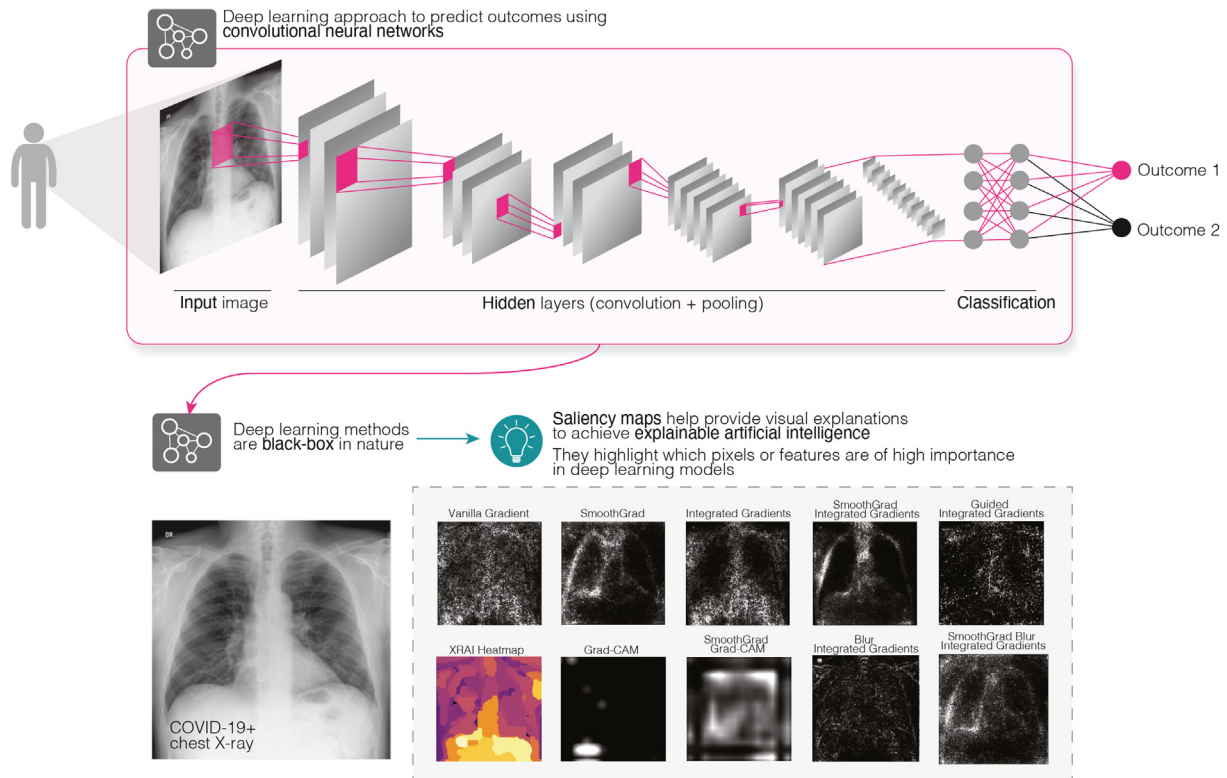


Figure 4 DL approaches are black box in nature. Convolutional neural networks (CNNs) contain many hidden and complex layers. What is learned in these layers can be enigmatic and often means that results are difficult to interpret. To achieve explainable AI, saliency maps help visualise which features on the input images are particularly important while a CNN is making a prediction. In other words, these maps tell us which parts of the image are paid most attention to for a CNN to derive an outcome. Here, we show a variety of saliency maps computed in Python v3.8.5 (Python Software Foundation, Wilmington, Delaware, USA) with TensorFlow CNNs (v2.9.1)²⁶¹ and the Saliency library (v0.2.0).²⁶² The sample chest radiograph was obtained from an online COVID-19 database.^{263,264}

recent years. The presence of tumour-infiltrating lymphocytes (TILs) has been strongly associated with favourable oncological outcome⁷¹ and ICI response,⁷² and the TIL–radiomics relationship has been explored most extensively in breast cancer using MRI or mammography images.^{48,73–76} Radiomics prediction of CD8-positive T-lymphocyte presence or abundance has been demonstrated in a number of tumour-type specific studies covering hepatobiliary,^{77,78} lung,⁷⁹ and GI^{80,81} cancers, as well as in a pancancer study, which further achieved predictive significance in terms of ICI response in a subset of selected tumour types.⁸² Other ICI biomarkers predicted radiomically in the literature include measures of tumour mutational burden,^{83,84} microsatellite instability^{83,85–87} and PD-1/PD-L1/PD-L2 expression.^{88–90}

Preoperative staging is a further area that may benefit from the use of radiomics. MRI radiomics can predict head and neck cancer stage,⁹¹ while CT-based radiomics showed significant associations with overall stage and primary tumour stage in lung cancer.⁹² In addition, in both lung and head and neck cancer patients, the addition of radiomics improved prognostication based on TNM stage alone.⁹² Several other studies showed good prediction of metastatic disease in lung cancer patients using CT^{93,94} or PET/CT⁹⁵ radiomics. In addition, diffusion-weighted imaging (DWI)

radiomics has been shown to predict T, N, and overall stage, as well as perineural invasion in gastric cancer patients.^{96–98}

Predicting response to treatment

Exploration of the clinical utility of radiomics has expanded in recent years to include predicting response to specific oncological treatments. Prediction of the pathological and/or radiological response to neoadjuvant chemotherapy or chemoradiotherapy using MRI radiomics has been explored extensively in breast⁹⁹ and rectal^{100–104} cancers, and has also been reported in cervical¹⁰⁵ and head and neck¹⁰⁶ tumours. CT radiomics has been utilised in predicting response to first-line chemotherapy in gastric,¹⁰⁷ bladder,¹⁰⁸ lung,^{109,110} and ovarian^{15,111,112} tumours, and to neoadjuvant chemoradiotherapy response in oesophageal^{76,113} and lung^{114,115} cancers. Other oncological therapy classes for which responses have been predicted using radiomics have included anti-EGFR therapies in lung cancer,^{116–118} anti-HER2 treatment in breast cancer,^{119,120} transarterial chemoembolisation in HCC,^{121,122} and ICIs in a number of tumour types.^{82,123,124} Importantly, multi-stream data integration has been shown to improve radiomics-based neoadjuvant response prediction.^{15,125–127}

In addition, the field of delta-radiomics has become popular in recent years in assessing treatment response.

Delta-radiomics measures changes in imaging features over time, usually before and after therapy. This can reveal subtle early tumoural changes that precede measurable changes in size, thus having the potential to aid as a complementary tool to RECIST assessment. The use of delta-radiomics in treatment response assessment in brain, head and neck, lung, gastro-intestinal, colorectal, breast, prostate, kidney, and other malignancies (sarcoma, melanoma, and haematological) has been covered in a recent systematic review.¹²⁸ With the increasing use of immunotherapy in oncology, recent studies utilising delta-radiomics analyses have shown good prediction of immunotherapy treatment response^{129–134} as well as the potential to discriminate between pseudo-progression and true progression early during treatment.^{130,135}

Integrating radiomics with other data streams

The relationship between imaging features and associated tumour biology is under active investigation in the rapidly expanding field of *radiogenomics*. This integration of radiomics with other data types, including clinical and molecular data, has been shown in a range of tumour types to improve the accuracy of survival prediction compared to single modality predictions alone. Clinical data, such as nodal status,^{13,136} luminal/HER2-positive/triple-negative subtype,¹³ histological proliferation index or tumour size¹³⁶ have contributed to integrated MRI radiomics-based nomogram approaches that allow superior prediction of disease-free survival compared to imaging or clinical data alone in breast cancer. MRI radiomics features were shown to have superior prognostic significance compared to clinical and radiological models alone in glioblastoma, but performed best when integrated with clinical data including extent of surgical debulking, patient age, and performance status.¹³⁷

The addition of prognostic molecular markers to clinical and radiomics data has been associated with incremental enhancement in predictive performance, for instance by integrating IDH mutational^{14,138,139} or MGMT promoter methylation^{14,138–141} status with MRI radiomics and clinical features in glioblastoma. Clinical measures of routine circulating markers can also contribute to improved outcome prediction using radiomics, for instance with the inclusion of prostate-specific antigen (PSA)¹⁴² and carcinoembryonic antigen (CEA)¹⁴³ levels within MRI- and CT-based radiomics–clinical modelling of prostate and pancreatic cancers, respectively; however, in patients with ovarian cancer, the prediction of response to neoadjuvant chemotherapy based on radiomics, clinical data, and CA125 could not be improved significantly when circulating tumour DNA (ctDNA) assessment was included.¹⁵ The integration of gene expression data with CT, MRI, or PET radiomics has also been shown to increase the accuracy of survival predictions across various tumour types.^{144–147}

Non-oncological applications of radiomics

Radiomics is potentially applicable to many diseases, with the only requirement being a dataset containing a radiological volume-of-interest and an outcome. Support

coming from cancer imaging programmes in particular^{148,149} and the greater availability of oncological datasets has resulted in other applications being less common and well-established.^{2,150} Although much of the radiomics research outside oncology is in its infancy, there is growing interest in its utility in a variety of other diseases (see Fig 2), with promising results in several areas (see Fig 5 for overview of non-oncological applications of radiomics).

Neurological

Diagnosis and classification of both acute ischaemic and haemorrhagic stroke have been demonstrated,^{151–154} whilst multiple prognostic applications also show potential. Functional outcome at discharge,^{155–158} evaluation of cognitive impairment,¹⁵⁹ risk of haemorrhagic transformation of ischaemia,¹⁶⁰ risk of haematoma expansion,^{161–164} and risk of malignant cerebral oedema^{165–167} have all been investigated. CT/CT angiography (CTA) radiomics may indicate the likelihood of recanalisation following administration of thrombolysis^{158,168} or mechanical thrombectomy,^{169,170} which could ultimately prevent patients undergoing high-risk, but likely futile, treatment.

Textural analysis of multiple sclerosis (MS) was first explored in 1999 when Mathias *et al.* analysed the potential for monitoring spinal cord lesions.¹⁷¹ Greater textural heterogeneity on MRI has been shown to be a potential measure of tissue integrity, correlating with more severe myelin and axonal pathology.¹⁷² Multiple studies have subsequently demonstrated that active lesions can be distinguished from chronic, indolent plaques^{173–175} and may allow for early diagnosis.¹⁷⁶ Other neurological applications include Parkinson's disease,^{177–182} Alzheimer's disease^{183,184} and schizophrenia.^{185–187}

Cardiovascular

Radiomics applied to coronary atherosclerotic plaques has been shown to be predictive of major cardiac events and may distinguish advanced from early plaques.^{188–190} It can even identify unique morphologic patterns specific to specific cardiovascular risk factors, e.g., cocaine-use,¹⁹¹ demonstrating the potential for individualised management.¹⁹²

Cardiac CTA radiomics may allow for accurate assessment of the myocardium where cardiac MRI is not available and reduce or even avoid the use of gadolinium.¹⁹³ Multiple studies suggest it is possible to diagnose and subclassify acute^{194–200} and chronic^{201–203} myocardial infarction, myocarditis,^{204,205} and cardiomyopathy^{19,206–209} on cross-sectional imaging. Applying these techniques to echocardiography may allow for detection of left ventricular remodelling²¹⁰ and may be able to differentiate pannus from thrombus or vegetation in patients with suspected prosthetic valve obstruction on CT.²¹¹

Studies have additionally demonstrated potential applications to vascular disease, for example in predicting the risk of expansion and rupture of abdominal aortic aneurysms²¹² and outcome after endovascular aortic repair (EVAR),^{213,214} whilst textural analysis of carotid ultrasound images has been shown to determine stroke risk from carotid artery disease.^{215,216}

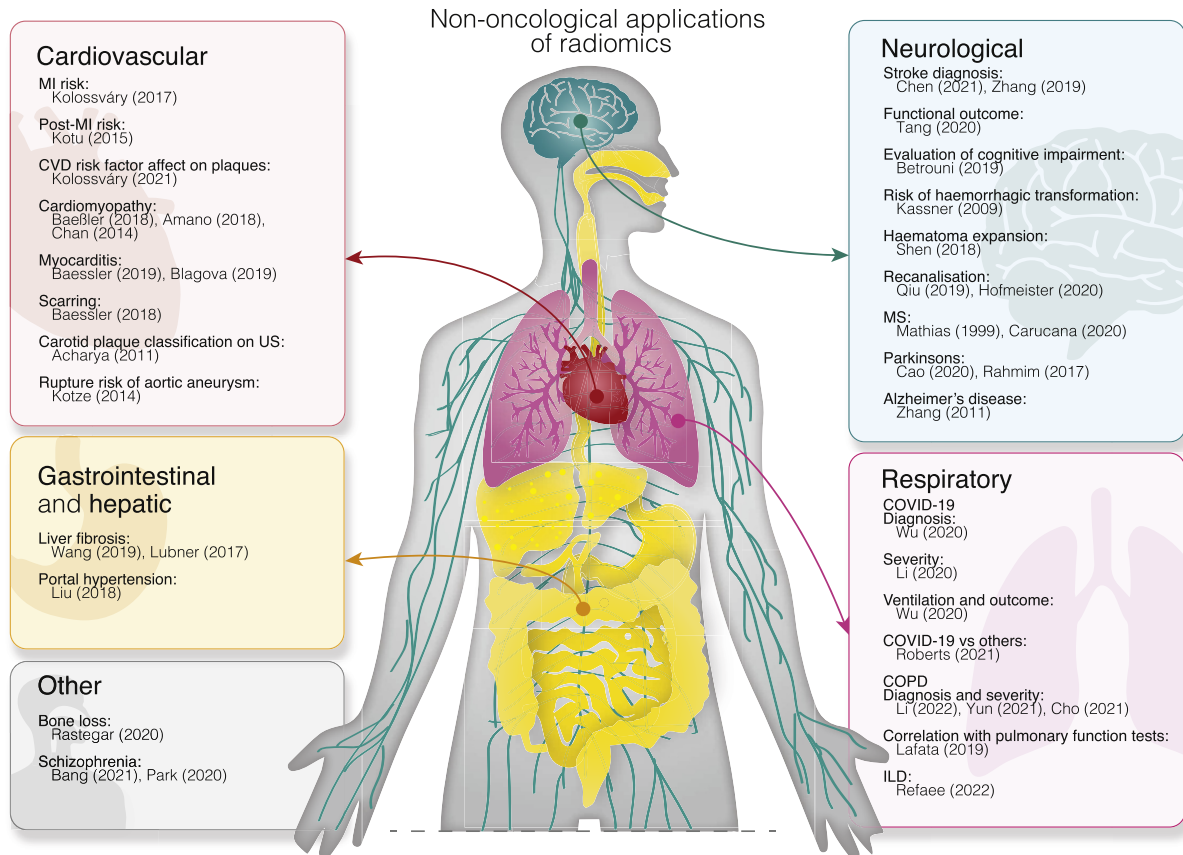


Figure 5 Non-oncological applications of radiomics.

Respiratory

Since the onset of the coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19) pandemic, there have been a large number of studies examining potential uses of radiomics. Attempts have been made to diagnose^{217–219} and monitor²²⁰ the disease, predict severity^{221–223} or the need for mechanical ventilation or mortality^{224–226} using chest radiography and CT. The ability to distinguish COVID-19 from influenza and other non-COVID pneumonias may also be possible^{227–231}; however, the standards of research have failed to allow for meaningful clinical adoption during the pandemic to date.⁴⁵

Diagnosis, severity, and prognosis of chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD) may be predicted by radiomics analysis,^{232–235} and results correspond to pulmonary function tests.^{232,236,237} It may be possible to stratify risk of developing the condition^{233,238} and identify sub-clinical smoking-related lung injury.²³⁹ Ultimately, it may allow for more accurate identification of disease phenotypes, allowing for more personalised and targeted therapies.^{240–242}

Similar applications may be found in interstitial lung disease (ILD), where studies have attempted to diagnose idiopathic pulmonary fibrosis (IPF),²⁴³ discriminate between multiple types of ILD,²⁴⁴ and quantify risk of lung cancer.²⁴⁵

Gastrointestinal and hepatic

A prospective, multicentre study found that radiomics assessment of elastography was an excellent surrogate of histological staging in hepatic fibrosis and is superior to

conventional two-dimensional shear-wave elastography.²⁴⁶ Radiomics of contrast-enhanced CT may provide similar insight, with subtle changes in heterogeneity corresponding to the presence and severity of fibrosis.^{247,248} Furthermore, radiomics may offer a non-invasive opportunity to diagnose clinically significant portal hypertension.²⁴⁹

Radiomics may be able to assist in differentiating Crohn's disease from ulcerative colitis.²⁵⁰ In Crohn's disease, it may be possible to identify patients at higher risk of surgery²⁵¹ or loss of response to biological treatments,²⁵² assisting clinicians to identify patients who require stricter monitoring or different therapeutic regimes.

Non-oncological integrating radiomics with other data streams

Although non-oncological multiomics integration has been limited to date, radiogenomics has shown promise in identifying patients with mild cognitive impairment who are most at risk of Alzheimer's disease, potentially allowing for personalised treatment aiming to slow progression.^{253–255} In IPF, a radiogenomics approach provided additional insight into disease progression and response to treatment.²⁵⁶

Radiotranscriptomics applied to peri-vascular adipose tissue on CT may be a marker of tissue inflammation and has potential prognostic applications in coronary artery disease²⁵⁷ and COVID-19.²⁵⁸ Furthermore, this approach

suggested the alpha variant of COVID-19 caused higher vascular inflammation than the original strain and treating such patients with dexamethasone improved outcomes.²⁵⁸

Conclusion

The Royal College of Radiologists believe the advent of medicine's AI age will herald the most fundamental change in healthcare delivery since the foundation of the NHS over 70 years ago.²⁵⁹ Of these AI-associated health technologies, radiomics may prove the most impactful by allowing us to bridge the gap between medical imaging and personalised medicine.⁴²

To date, research has been focused on oncological applications; however, this review has highlighted the increasing use of radiomics techniques in a raft of other diseases.

In order to create tools with clinical utility, prospective trials that validate radiomics signatures on external datasets are required. Therefore, safe sharing of datasets between centres or publicly is a requirement for the field to develop further and for radiomics-based AI tools to make the transition into clinical workflows. There is also need for standardisation of analysis, in line with those recommended by IBSI. Although standardisation of image acquisition would be beneficial, it is unlikely to be feasible between different vendors and scanners. Therefore, research on the identification of predictive radiomics that remain robust, especially against differences in image acquisition and reconstruction, is more important than ever. In addition, heterogeneous datasets for model training and testing, and entirely independent data sets for validation, would be desirable for all radiomics studies. For the clinical setting, an interdisciplinary approach combining the knowledge and insight of key stakeholders, including radiologists, pathologists, oncologists, medical physicists, imaging scientists, data scientists, and patients, is necessary to accelerate the penetrance of radiomics-based tools into patient care.

As the domain experts in medical imaging, radiologists are uniquely placed to lead these developments, which will augment our diagnostic skills. This will require radiologists to educate themselves on the basics of how tools based on radiomics and AI are designed and tested, so that we can play an active role in their development, and appraise and scrutinise their utility on our patients' behalf. Given the prospective centrality of these tools in the provision of healthcare, changes to both undergraduate medical and radiology training curriculums may be warranted. These efforts would reinforce the value of radiology into the future.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

Acknowledgements

The funders for the project are: NIHR BRC Cambridge, United Kingdom; The Mark Foundation for Cancer Research,

United States; Cancer Research UK, United Kingdom; Innovative Medicines Initiative, Belgium; EPSRC, United Kingdom; Horizon 2020, European Union; CRUK, United Kingdom; EFPIA, Belgium; The Austrian Science Fund, Austria; Wellcome Trust, United Kingdom. The views expressed are those of the authors and not necessarily those of the NHS, the NIHR, or the Department of Health and Social Care.

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